

Chapter 157-1

The cold winter sun penetrated through the glass, refracting into the room, and happened to illuminate the five words "Divorce Agreement."

Those words gradually blurred.

Mist filled her vision, and her heart seemed to stop beating in that instant.

After a long while, Xu Qingzhu finally moved her lips, but no sound came out.

She was trying to find her voice, but to no avail.

The good mood that had rarely come from a full night's sleep instantly vanished into thin air.

In the quiet room, Xu Qingzhu sat in the chair, reading the words on the sticky note over and over again, until the mist in her eyes became so thick she couldn't see anything.

She slowly closed her eyes, and tears fell onto the A4 paper.

This was a rare sunny winter day in Haizhou City.

Xu Qingzhu sat woodenly in the room for an entire day, her phone on Do Not Disturb mode, without eating anything.

Until nightfall descended and the entire city sank into darkness, the streetlights flickered on in an instant.

Like a beam of light shining into the darkness.

Yet, Xu Qingzhu's world had completely fallen into darkness.

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In the morning, Liang Shi drove around half of Haizhou City like a wandering ghost before dawn.

She saw the morning sun falling on the Yujiang Bridge and witnessed the city's dawn.

Everything seemed full of life and vitality, but she had no intention of appreciating it.

In the end, with nowhere to go, she bought some alcohol and went to find Zhao Xuning.

At that time, Zhao Xuning was still sound asleep. She opened the door impatiently with her hair sticking up in all directions, her voice hoarse as she said through gritted teeth: "You'd better have something important."

"I'm getting divorced." Liang Shi said in a low voice, standing at the door.

Zhao Xuning was stunned, and her sleepiness and morning grumpiness vanished without a trace in an instant.

"What do you mean?" Zhao Xuning closed the door behind her.

Liang Shi placed the alcohol she'd bought on the coffee table and shrugged with a bitter smile: "Exactly what it sounds like."

"Did you get the certificate done?"¹ Zhao Xuning asked.

Liang Shi: "...Not yet."

"Then how is that a divorce?" Zhao Xuning smoothed her hair, rummaged through a drawer for a hair tie, and casually tied her hair up. "Besides, aren't you and Xu Qingzhu in the honeymoon phase? How could you have fought?"

As soon as she finished speaking, Liang Shi said in a low voice: "I signed the divorce agreement."

Zhao Xuning's hand that was tying her hair paused, then she unhurriedly put on her glasses, and her vision finally became clearer.

She didn't pay attention to Liang Shi and went straight to the bathroom to wash her face. When she came out, Liang Shi was drinking in sullen silence.

Zhao Xuning walked over and opened a can for herself as well. "So?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She hadn't expected Zhao Xuning to accept it so well.

She'd thought she would at least ask about the reason or something.

But this was also fine. Liang Shi came to find Zhao Xuning precisely because she always had a sense of propriety and boundaries. When you treated her as a close friend, you might get hurt by her somewhat cold attitude.

But when encountering situations like this, you'd feel it was so good to have a friend like Zhao Xuning.

She would never ask too many questions.

"I have nowhere to stay." Liang Shi said. "Let me crash here for a few days."

Hearing this, Zhao Xuning took out her phone and called her—it was powered off.

"Not going to work?" Zhao Xuning asked.

Liang Shi shook her head: "Just wrapped up a production. I'll see if there's any work these few days."

"Your phone isn't even on—where would work come from?" Zhao Xuning took a sip of alcohol, felt a bitter taste in her mouth, got up and opened the refrigerator, then focused on cutting vegetables and cooking.

She had no intention of insisting that Liang Shi say anything.

And Liang Shi was content to amuse herself, chatting casually with her for a bit before drinking in silence.

The dishes Zhao Xuning made to go with the drinks tasted decent. Liang Shi ate some, then drank another can of beer, and her head ached a bit.

"I need to go home for a bit." Zhao Xuning said. "Your activity space is limited to the common areas and that bedroom. My bedroom—don't even touch the door."

"Got it, Dr. Zhao." Liang Shi nodded and got up to walk toward the room Zhao Xuning had indicated.

It was similar to the previous bedroom, both having a very minimalist² decorating style.

Simple and clear, but with all the necessary furniture.

Liang Shi had been awake almost the entire night and had been drinking all last night, so now her head was splitting.

She threw her already powered-off phone into the drawer, lay on the bed, and buried herself in sleep.

She didn't even notice when Zhao Xuning left.

Zhao Xuning sat in the living room and cleaned up the two empty bottles, and the living room returned to its untouched appearance.

She sat on the sofa and sent a message to Xu Qingzhu: What are you doing?

The other party didn't reply.

A few seconds later, Zhao Xuning withdrew the message.

She couldn't be bothered to deal with these matters.

Zhao Xuning's home was decorated like a hotel, with everything neatly categorized and placed by this obsessive-compulsive person. She hired cleaning services three times a week.

Aside from the bedroom, study, bathroom, and kitchen, she rarely went anywhere else.

And the master bedroom had its own bathroom.

So she could take Liang Shi in for a few days.

1. In China, an official divorce requires going to the civil affairs bureau to obtain a divorce certificate, similar to how marriage requires obtaining a marriage certificate. Simply signing a divorce agreement is not legally binding without this official step. ⇐
2. The original Chinese term "性冷淡风" literally translates to "frigid/cold style," which in Chinese interior design terminology refers to a minimalist, neutral-toned aesthetic that emphasizes clean lines and simplicity. This design trend became popular in China in the 2010s, inspired by Scandinavian and Japanese minimalism. ⇐

Chapter 157-2

After Zhao Xuning tidied up the house, she sat on the living room sofa and played on her phone for a while, then went to the master bedroom bathroom to take a shower. She also took a brand new set of toiletries from the storage room and placed them in the outer washroom, sticking a note on the door to remind Liang Shi where everything was.

She put on simple makeup, grabbed her bag, and headed out.

This trip home was probably going to be about the matchmaking issue again, which was nothing new for Zhao Xuning.

And she already had a mature set of responses to deal with it.

She had no plans to go on blind dates, nor did she plan to get married.

At least not at this stage.

After breaking up with Shen Hui, she had briefly wanted to meet new people and start new relationships to distract herself.

But she later discovered that no one compared to Shen Hui.

So she cut off any ambiguous relationships with others and never had such thoughts again.

She used to always hear people say that after a breakup, you just need to find someone new and you'll be fine.

But after Zhao Xuning tried it herself, she realized that when it came to matters of the heart, it was like a fish drinking water—only the fish knows whether it's cold or warm.¹

Being in contact with new people wouldn't fill the emptiness in her heart.

On the contrary, it only made her miss the past even more.

No matter which street she walked down or which star she saw, she would always think of those past memories.

And then find the current person even more boring.

She had spent many years building rapport with Shen Hui.

All those memories were incredibly precious.

The thought of dating someone else made her feel completely uncomfortable.

So eventually, she let go of others, and also let go of herself.

Zhao Xuning drove back home. There were quite a lot of people there—it was a family gathering. Not only was her sister there, but Zhao Ying and Zhao Ling were there too.

Their family was quite large, with seven or eight people in her generation, half of whom were already married.

Zhao Xuning wasn't actually that old, but because she had skipped grades and started working very quickly, people had the impression that she was older.

While eating at the table, an elder even asked her how old she was in her thirties this year.

Zhao Xuning paused and answered coldly: "Twenty-five."

"That's still young." The elder said. "But it's already time to start dating. Date for two years, get married, and you should have children early."

Zhao Xuning had gotten used to hearing this kind of thing. She ate quietly, but when she heard the words "children," her hand gripping the chopsticks suddenly tightened. Her throat felt itchy for an instant, and she turned her head to cough.

Zhao Ying, who was sitting beside her, came to her rescue: "What's the rush? We're still young."

"You're still young?" Zhao Ying's mother suddenly spoke up, her tone chilly. "You're almost thirty. By the way, are you and Yang Shuyan really together? I saw online that you two are dating?"

Zhao Ying was instantly stunned speechless.²

Meanwhile, Zhao Ling lowered her head, trying to hold back her laughter.

"That's not true at all." Zhao Ying waved her hand, lying without batting an eye. "Those are just marketing accounts making things up. Yang Shuyan's fans and I have been at each other's throats—why would I be with her?"

Zhao Ying's mother poked Zhao Ying's head: "Don't let your uncles and aunties see you as a joke. You're always hyping up CP ships³ online, and none of them are real."

Zhao Ying: "..."

"Xi Pi"⁴ means CP.

Mrs. Zhao, who was obsessed with playing cards and ballroom dancing, only half-understood entertainment industry terminology. She said it with a straight face, but Zhao Ying explained: "That's all just for work. I'm not close with any of them."

"Then who are you close with?" Mrs. Zhao asked. "Last time I asked you to get an autograph from that person, you also said you weren't close with them, even though you've clearly been photographed together."

"Which person?" Zhao Ying asked.

Mrs. Zhao paused: "The one from that period drama before, that really handsome guy..."

"Mom, he's been arrested for soliciting prostitutes." Zhao Ying said. "If I were close with him, wouldn't my career be ruined?"⁵

Mrs. Zhao: "...You're useless."

Zhao Ying was speechless.

But she and her mom were often like this—they'd have a battle of three hundred rounds over nothing, and neither could win in a war of words.

They argued earnestly and intensely, drawing all the attention that had been focused on Zhao Xuning over to themselves.

So Zhao Xuning ate quietly.

But what was meant to come would eventually come. After the meal, she had just picked up her car keys, planning to make an excuse about having something at the hospital and leave, when her father called out to her.

"Come here." Father Zhao called to her seriously. "I need to talk to you about something."

Zhao Xuning paused. "I have things to do."

Father Zhao looked at her coldly: "You can do them after I'm done talking with you."

Zhao Xuning held her keys and followed him upstairs.

In the study, her mother and sister were also there.

"The people here." Father Zhao got straight to the point as soon as he entered. "Pick one."

It seemed less like picking a person and more like picking cabbage at the market.

Zhao Xuning frowned and glanced at the roster that had at least a dozen pages. "I'm not going."

"I'm not asking you to go on a blind date." Father Zhao said. "Pick one to get to know, and get married next year."

Zhao Xuning: "..."

Even more rushed than before.

Zhao Xuning exhaled lightly. "What do you mean?"

"Your sister had already given birth to Lianlian at your age." Father Zhao said. "Look at you—all you do is hospital, home, hospital, home. How are you supposed to date like this? Forget dating. It's not going to work out anyway. Just pick one and get married."

Zhao Xuning: "..."

"Impossible." Zhao Xuning refused. "I'm not getting married."

"Are you still in contact with that girl from before?" Father Zhao was suddenly alert, his brow furrowing. "The one you dated in university, the one you said you wanted to marry... You two haven't broken up?"

Zhao Xuning: "..."

"We broke up." Zhao Xuning said.

"Then that's fine." Father Zhao said. "It's not about whether she was good enough for you or not. The main thing is that the gap between you two was too big. Zhao Xuning, you need to understand that when it comes to your marriage, you can't be willful."

When it came to her major and marriage, Zhao Xuning only had one choice of freedom.

She had given up the Zhao family's business to her sister and chosen the major she liked.

In marriage, she had lost the initiative.

Her marriage had to contribute to the Zhao family and stabilize the Zhao family's company.

This was something Zhao Xuning had known for a long time.

So she had never planned to date. Meeting Shen Hui... was an accident.

This accident had caused her to have a huge fight with her family, and the longest she went without coming home was nearly half a year.

At that time, her sister came as a mediator. It also happened to be near the time she was applying to graduate school abroad, so using the excuse that she was still young, these matters were suppressed and no one mentioned them.

Most crucially, her father had investigated Shen Hui's identity, but only found the fabricated layer that the Shen family had created for Shen Hui.

Her sister only knew because when those events happened, her sister happened to be on a business trip there.

At that time, her sister had advised her not to be too stubborn—going against their father wouldn't end well.

But later, seeing her persistence, her sister had switched sides and said she would try to persuade their father.

But unexpectedly, that time, Shen Fenghe slapped her at the hospital.

And her sister had been standing not far away.

Afterward, her sister confronted Shen Fenghe at the hospital.

Thinking back on what happened that day was like a nightmare.

Now that her father was bringing up old matters, Zhao Xuning stood there feeling a terrible headache, as if millions of ants were biting her.

She furrowed her brow tightly, radiating impatience from her entire body.

1. This is a Chinese idiom (如鱼饮水，冷暖自知) meaning that only the person experiencing something truly knows how it feels—like a fish drinking water, only it knows whether the water is cold or warm. It expresses that emotional experiences are deeply personal and cannot be fully understood by outsiders. ⇐
2. The original Chinese slang "蚌住" (bàng zhù) is internet slang meaning to be so shocked or embarrassed that one is rendered speechless, like a clam snapping shut. ⇐
3. CP (Couple Pairing) refers to the practice of fans "shipping" or supporting romantic pairings between celebrities, whether real or imagined. "Hyping up CP ships" refers to deliberately creating or promoting such pairings for marketing purposes. ⇐
4. "西皮" (xī pí) is a transliteration of "CP" using Chinese characters that sound similar. Mrs. Zhao uses this term showing she's somewhat aware of entertainment industry terminology but not fully fluent in it. ⇐
5. The phrase "凉了" (liáng le, literally "gone cold") is Chinese entertainment industry slang meaning a celebrity's career has become inactive or ruined due to scandal or other issues. ⇐

Chapter 157-3

But Father Zhao said: "Zhao Xuning, don't forget—when it comes to your major and marriage, you only have one choice."

"I remember." Zhao Xuning said. "But I don't want to get married."

"It's not up to you!" Father Zhao said. "You were bewitched by that woman. She's even two years older than you—what's so good about her?"

Zhao Xuning paused: "You don't need to know."

Her voice was very cold. She subconsciously raised her hand to adjust her glasses, but forgot that she wasn't wearing them today, and could only awkwardly withdraw her hand.

Father Zhao was so angry he choked for a moment, then said sternly: "Then what do you want?"

"To not marry." Zhao Xuning said. "From now on, you don't need to worry about me. I won't marry for an alliance."

Hearing this, Father Zhao stared at her in astonishment. "Zhao Xuning! Have I given you too much freedom these years?!"

Zhao Xuning lowered her gaze and nodded at him. "This has nothing to do with freedom."

"Then come back to the company!" Father Zhao said.

Zhao Xuning looked at him, pursed her lips, and suddenly said coldly: "Dad, I'm an adult now."

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The study of the Zhao family was as tense as ever, and it was difficult for Zhao Xuning to emerge from such an atmosphere unscathed.

In the end, it was her sister who mediated.

After leaving the house, Zhao Xuning got into the car. She had just fastened her seatbelt when the passenger door was opened and her sister got in. While fastening her seatbelt, her sister asked: "Are you still in contact with Shen Hui?"

Zhao Xuning paused: "Occasionally."

They only ran into each other in some very coincidental circumstances, and the atmosphere between them was even more tense than when she had been arguing with her father in the study just now.

There had been no private contact at all.

A few days ago, she'd heard that Shen Hui was going on blind dates with Yan Lin, though she didn't know if it had worked out.

At the mention of Shen Hui, Zhao Xuning's thoughts drifted a little. It was her sister's voice that pulled her back: "Is it that it has to be her for the rest of your life?"

Zhao Xuning: "..."

The car drove away from the Zhao residence and pulled over at an intersection.

Zhao Xuning's hand was still on the steering wheel. She curled her fingers and tapped lightly, then said with a bitter smile: "Not really."

"Then why won't you accept Father's suggestion?" Her sister said. "Ningning, you should know that compared to the Shen family, we're still a bit lacking."

"I know." Zhao Xuning said. "But if Shen Hui and I were together, I wouldn't care about any of that. Whether our future child takes the surname Shen or Zhao, whatever she wants—I'd be fine with it all. But..."

At this point, Zhao Xuning suddenly stopped. She covered her forehead with one hand, realizing that she had impulsively said a lot of things that didn't make logical sense.

She closed her eyes and took a deep breath. "Sorry, sis."

"It's fine." Her sister said. "Actually, I just came to ask you—what exactly do you want? So I can know how to handle things."

The car fell silent for a long time.

Zhao Xuning spoke softly: "I've never deliberately been waiting for Shen Hui. I know we can't go back to how we were. I brought her too much pain. I've been trying to move forward, but after trying for so long, I realized I've just been running in place."

Zhao Xuning felt powerless against this feeling too.

A deep sense of helplessness enveloped her, preventing her from thinking about these things. If she thought about them on some lonely late night, she would definitely drink until the early hours of the morning.

Her life had become extremely dismal, like she had returned to the time right after breaking up with Shen Hui.

She had always thought that after breaking up with Shen Hui, she had been moving forward, constantly moving forward.

But she hadn't expected that she had been walking in circles all along.

Round and round, always ending up at the starting point.

"So you're waiting for her?" Her sister asked tentatively.

Zhao Xuning shook her head.

Zhao Xuning's sister was also someone who leaned toward rational thinking, so she didn't quite understand Zhao Xuning's current state. She sat there thinking for a few seconds before asking again: "Then what exactly do you want?"

Zhao Xuning paused.

After a long while, she let out a deep sigh: "I don't know."

Chapter 157-4

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Those three words "I don't know" truly encompassed far too much.

Zhao Xuning had been in this state ever since she broke up with Shen Hui.

During the time when she was dating Shen Hui, whenever anyone asked her what she wanted, she could clearly and decisively articulate her needs.

But now, the moment she heard this question, she would subconsciously start to avoid it.

Because she didn't dare say what she wanted.

Because those desires had become extravagant hopes.

Things that had once been within reach.

Zhao Xuning drove all the way home. She called a colleague downstairs to swap shifts, and only when she entered and saw an unfamiliar pair of shoes did she remember there was someone else in the house.

Liang Shi actually had somewhere to go.

The keys to the apartment that Liang Xinzhou had given her before were in her hands, and she could move there anytime.

But she hadn't gone there, instead coming to Zhao Xuning's place.

Perhaps during these difficult days, she didn't want to be alone.

Zhao Xuning turned on the projector, put on her VR headset, and started watching a movie.

She was also used to the pace of living alone and didn't change just because there was one more person in the house.

As for Liang Shi, she slept until evening, and only opened the door to the guest room when the sky was filled with rosy clouds.

For a modern person, being without a phone felt like something was missing.

After waking up, Liang Shi also instinctively reached for her phone. Only after grabbing a phone with a black screen did she realize she had moved out and had turned off her phone.

As she sat on the bed in a daze, the orange-pink clouds spread across the horizon, and the remaining light fell through and sprinkled on her. She raised her hand to shield her eyes and actually felt a few drops of water.

Liang Shi sniffled, pulled a tissue from the bedside, and wiped the moisture from her hand.

Then she got up lazily, went out, and upon pushing open the door saw Zhao Xuning absorbed in watching a movie. She walked over and sat down familiarly. "Dr. Zhao, are you hungry?"

Zhao Xuning took off her glasses and earphones. "What?"

"What are we eating tonight?" Liang Shi asked.

Zhao Xuning shrugged: "I do intermittent fasting at night. I don't eat."

Liang Shi: "?"

"Didn't you drink with me before?" Liang Shi asked.

Zhao Xuning: "That was an exception."

Cold voice, cold demeanor, mechanical like an AI.

Liang Shi was silent for a moment. "Let's have spicy crayfish¹, the most numbing and spiciest kind."

Zhao Xuning frowned and looked at her, as if asking—aren't you someone who can't handle spicy food?

But Liang Shi nodded to herself. She instinctively went to order delivery, only to find that her phone was off. She looked at Zhao Xuning: "Dr. Zhao, you order it."

Zhao Xuning: "?"

While ordering the delivery, Zhao Xuning asked: "Between you and Xu Qingzhu, who brought it up?"

Liang Shi was startled, pausing for a moment before reacting. She leaned her head over to Zhao Xuning's side to look at the screen. "I did."

Zhao Xuning nodded: "Alright."

She went ahead and ordered the most numbing and spiciest kind.

"Then what about Xu Qingzhu?" Zhao Xuning asked.

Liang Shi: "...At home, or at the company. I don't know."

She was very calm, so calm that she didn't seem like someone who had just gotten divorced.

But it might also be because she was the one who initiated the divorce, so she felt more at ease.

However, her eyes were more swollen than when she'd seen her this morning, so she wasn't completely indifferent.

Zhao Xuning glanced at her, put her phone aside, and let her gaze fall back on the big screen.

She clicked play, and Liang Shi said in surprise: "I really like this one too."

Zhao Xuning nodded: "This one is pretty obscure."

Liang Shi shrugged: "But it's really good."

Zhao Xuning didn't speak again after that. She was a person of few words, especially today after going home and being in a bad mood. She just wanted to watch movies to dispel the frustration in her heart.

As for Liang Shi, normally—at least in front of Xiao Bai and Sister Wang before—she was pathetically quiet. But now compared to Zhao Xuning, she was actually the talkative one.

Though not by much. Occasionally during exciting parts of the movie, she would comment that the cinematography was really good, or that this frame was really beautiful.

In less than half an hour, the crayfish was delivered.

There was still beer in the fridge that Liang Shi had bought this morning, so the two of them sat by the coffee table and started eating.

Liang Shi really couldn't handle spicy food. If it were the original owner's body from before, she could have tolerated it a little, but her own body would be brought to tears by the spiciness.

Zhao Xuning was slightly better than her, but not by much.

By the time they finished eating, their noses and eyes were redder than the crayfish on the table.

Liang Shi looked at Zhao Xuning through the watery haze, and then Zhao Xuning opened two bottles of her treasured red wine.

After drinking too much, Liang Shi said indignantly: "How can there be people who are 100% compatible?! Why do I have to get divorced?! I finally had a home... and just like that, it's falling apart."

"At least you got married." Zhao Xuning was also a bit tipsy. "I didn't even get to marry."

Liang Shi glanced at her: "Then go get married!"

Zhao Xuning: "...Shut up!"

"You stubborn ghost." Liang Shi said.

Zhao Xuning: "...Like you're any better?"

The retort was filled with thick sarcasm.

Liang Shi froze, then raised her glass to change the subject: "Come on, come on, let's drink."

The topic was thus brushed aside.

But after a few more glasses of wine, Zhao Xuning leaned against the sofa and rambled: "What's wrong with Xu Qingzhu? Did you two fight before the divorce? She came to me a few days ago to get sleep medication."

Hearing this, Liang Shi felt a dull ache in her heart, as if something had struck her. "It should be fine after this."

As long as she left, as long as they divorced, everything would be fine.

"Then why does it feel like you're not sad at all?" Zhao Xuning asked. "Didn't you used to love Xu Qingzhu to death?"

Liang Shi: "..."

After a long while, Liang Shi said quietly: "We haven't really divorced yet."

In the future... she would still win her back.

These words puzzled Zhao Xuning, but Liang Shi refused to say any more no matter what.

She didn't dare have even a hint of such thoughts, afraid they would be detected.

She couldn't have thoughts about exploiting bugs in the world's rules for even a second.

So all of this was real. She really was going to divorce Xu Qingzhu, following the development of the plot line.

She was leaving this time and space for Xu Qingzhu and Lu Jiayi, this pair of Soulmates.

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1. "麻小" (má xiǎo) is short for "麻辣小龙虾" (málà xiǎolóngxiā), meaning "numbing spicy crayfish." It's a popular Chinese dish featuring crayfish cooked in a sauce with Sichuan peppercorns (which create a numbing sensation) and chili peppers. It's a beloved late-night snack and drinking food in China. ↩

Chapter 157-5

"Aren't you worried then?" Zhao Xuning said. "Xu Qingzhu was already very sought after before."

Liang Shi paused slightly. "Not really worried. I'm only worried about her health."

The nightmares that came day and night, the endless psychological suggestion—these would push Xu Qingzhu into a mental breakdown.

Compared to all that, Liang Shi felt it was better to follow the plot line's development.

First, divorce—which meant the world line had progressed to the step where the original owner exits.

And when she came back, it would be in her own name.

As for the plot line where Xu Qingzhu and Lu Jiayi get married, as long as she didn't let those two fall in love with each other, she still had a chance.

And she had already discovered a pattern: even though Lu Jiayi and Xu Qingzhu knew each other now, and even with the accumulated favorable impression from before, they were merely slightly closer friends.

Lu Jiayi wasn't the type of person who would interfere in someone else's relationship.

And Xu Qingzhu had given Liang Shi so much confidence, which was why Liang Shi had made this decision.

Without consulting Xu Qingzhu.

Once she consulted her, this plan would mean failure.

The worst result would simply be following the original plot line's development. If Liang Shi failed to exploit the bug, then Liang Shi would have no regrets.

At least one of them—her or Xu Qingzhu—would be happy, right?

Liang Shi had thought all of this through before she left.

This thought had been frequently surfacing for many days now, so she kept summarizing the matter with Chen Liuying, reviewing Sun Chengcheng's appearance, including the differences between the original plot points and the current timeline's plot points.

In the end, she decided to exploit the bug.

Liang Shi spoke in riddles, and even someone as smart as Zhao Xuning couldn't understand.

But this didn't stop Zhao Xuning from rambling on with her.

A drunk Zhao Xuning was rather talkative, as if she wanted to say all the things she hadn't said when she was pretending to be cold and aloof.

She hugged the wine bottle and complained to Liang Shi: "You know what? When Shen Hui and I were together, she was always the one coaxing me."

Liang Shi: "...That's too much."

Zhao Xuning: "I coaxed her too, but I had no patience. If only I had been more patient with her."

Liang Shi: "...It's too late for regrets."

Zhao Xuning: "You're right. Although you're getting divorced, at least you got married. I didn't even get to marry."

Liang Shi: "...That is pretty hard to bear."

Zhao Xuning: "We had agreed to get married after graduating from university, but on my way to propose to her, I got called away by my advisor, and then the proposal never happened."

Liang Shi: "...That's just too tragic."

Zhao Xuning: "Later, when I was about to graduate from my master's program, I was also planning it. But I didn't expect someone to drug me, and they even called Shen Hui to come see."

Liang Shi: "...Damn, that person was too vicious."

Zhao Xuning: "Shen Hui got into a car accident... Her whole body was lying in blood, she bled so much... I was completely stunned at the time. That was the first time I cried in front of so many people."

Liang Shi: "...Sister Hui's life was too tragic, wasn't it?"

Zhao Xuning nodded: "Yeah. And we lost our child too. Otherwise, we could have had a grand wedding before the child was born. She loved pink and blue the most, and she also loved the sea. I had already figured out where to hold the wedding."

Liang Shi: "...A child?!"

Zhao Xuning smiled bitterly: "Yeah. Before anyone even knew she was coming, she had already completely disappeared."

Liang Shi didn't know how to comfort her for a moment.

Later that night, one of them slept on the sofa, the other on the floor.

The next morning when she woke up, Liang Shi sat up from the floor, looked around in a daze, then got up and went back to the room.

Chapter 157-6

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That was probably the most unrestrained day Liang Shi had ever had, and also the most depressing.

She used that method to force herself to forget those things.

Even though she knew she was exploiting a bug, she was also putting all her eggs in one basket doing this.

Strictly speaking, she was probably a pessimist.

Pessimistic thoughts, optimistic actions.

So she usually thought of the worst outcome.

Actually, her chances of winning were 50%.

Because Xu Qingzhu was someone who, when about to stab her, could use her last bit of clarity to turn the blade toward herself.

So Liang Shi dared to go all in on this gamble.

But there was still the possibility of other things happening.

If they really did happen one day, then she could only accept her fate.

However, the system had said that even the operating rules of the world would not interfere with people's emotions.

At most, there were initial impression points, and all emotional development afterward was entirely up to the people themselves, just like the system wouldn't interfere with the world's operating rules.

Even if there were so many villains in the dimensional worlds, as long as they weren't people who had been specifically monitored by the Administration Bureau, they would be handled by the human laws in those dimensional worlds, because all dimensional worlds had laws.

And the Administration Bureau only managed those who had been given "special treatment."

So Liang Shi's chances of winning were actually 70%.

But the divorce agreement was printed out by her, signed by her—she was genuinely experiencing all of this.

It was inevitable that she would feel terrible.

However, Liang Shi was only dejected for one day. The next morning after waking up, she charged and turned on her phone.

She opened all her social apps and took a look, finding that Xu Qingzhu hadn't sent her a single message or made a single call.

On the contrary, the active people in her social apps were all those she'd met while filming with the crew.

She went through all the messages, then switched to her chat with Xu Qingzhu, stared at their previous chat history for a while, and then closed it.

She turned airplane mode back on.

After Liang Shi and Zhao Xuning drank and chatted freely, the next day they tacitly avoided mentioning the drunken ramblings.

At least Liang Shi deliberately avoided bringing it up.

As for Zhao Xuning, she didn't know if the other person was like Xu Qingzhu and would black out after drinking too much.

But judging from her reaction, it didn't seem like it.

Because when Liang Shi mentioned that they had talked about Shen Hui last night, Zhao Xuning's eyelid twitched, and she looked up at her with an aura that said—if you dare say one more word, I'll kill you.

So Liang Shi obediently shut up.

But that said, Liang Shi was quite adept at starting new chapters after getting drunk.

In the past with film crews, there would be drinking at the opening banquet, and drinking at the wrap party.

Almost always drinking a lot.

So every time she drank felt like a new beginning.

Last night's drinking session had been satisfying. She wanted to know how Xu Qingzhu was doing, but didn't dare ask too much. She didn't even dare ask the friends around her, and could only silently scroll through Sally and the others' Moments¹.

And Xu Qingzhu had rarely posted something on Moments.

【The stars have disappeared. There's no more light.】

A very literary sentence.

Since they weren't mutual friends, she couldn't see the comments below, but the posting time was 03:20.

Three-thirty in the morning.

It was the time when Liang Shi was dead drunk and sleeping on the cold floor at Zhao Xuning's place.

She immediately felt guilty.

But soon, she saw that Lin Luoxi had posted something on Moments.

The accompanying photo was of Xu Qingzhu's profile.

She was sitting at her desk signing documents, her hair casually pinned up with a claw clip. A strand had fallen down to cover her profile, but light seeped through the gaps in her hair.

It made her look very gentle.

The caption was: 【What's it like having a beautiful workaholic as a boss? Exhausted to the point of vomiting blood.jpg】

Sally commented: 【Baby, hugs. Our Zhuzi junior sister is too crazy right now. Can't handle it, can't handle it!】

Liang Shi wanted to comment something, but deleted it after typing two characters.

Right, they were getting divorced.

They would become strangers.

These matters were no longer her business.

After consoling herself like this, Liang Shi went back to the guest room to pack up her things, then took some cash from her wallet and headed out.

Zhao Xuning was stunned when she saw the cash in her hand. "Is that joss paper?"²

Liang Shi: "..."

Rendered speechless for a moment, Liang Shi went along with her words: "Yes, I'm going to burn it for you."

Zhao Xuning: "..."

After meeting Zhao Xuning's gaze, Liang Shi educated her while heading out the door: "Joss paper is for dead people. We usually call this cash or RMB."

Zhao Xuning: "..."

To save face, Zhao Xuning said disdainfully: "Who even uses that anymore?"

Liang Shi pointed at herself with the money: "Me."

Zhao Xuning was completely speechless.

Because Liang Shi noticed there wasn't much food at her place, she was going out to buy groceries.

Plus, she was already freeloading the room, so there was no reason to also freeload food. So the considerate person had already planned to feed Zhao Xuning.

Liang Shi asked her: "What are you eating tonight?"

Zhao Xuning: "I'm on shift until ten tonight. I won't be back."

Liang Shi asked: "So you're eating at the hospital?"

Zhao Xuning shook her head: "I do intermittent fasting at night. I don't eat."

Liang Shi: "..."

While changing her shoes at the door, she said: "You said the same thing last night."

Zhao Xuning cleared her throat: "That was an exception."

Liang Shi's feeding plan failed, but she wasn't discouraged. "Then let's wait until tomorrow morning. I'll definitely make you eat breakfast."

Zhao Xuning paused again: "I don't eat breakfast either."

Liang Shi: "?"

A few seconds later, Liang Shi said through gritted teeth: "Dr. Zhao, the fact that you've survived until now is truly a miracle."

Zhao Xuning: "...That's bordering on personal attack."

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1. "Moments" (朋友圈, péngyou quān) refers to WeChat Moments, a social media feature on WeChat (China's dominant messaging app) similar to Facebook's timeline or Instagram's feed, where users can post photos, text updates, and see their friends' posts. ↩
 2. Joss paper (纸钱, zhǐqián) is paper made to resemble money that is burned as an offering to deceased ancestors or spirits in Chinese traditional practices. It's commonly used during funerals, the Qingming Festival (Tomb-Sweeping Day), and other occasions to honor the dead. Zhao Xuning's confusion about physical cash suggests she, like many young urban Chinese, rarely uses physical currency due to the prevalence of mobile payment systems like WeChat Pay and Alipay. ↩

Chapter 157-7

Liang Shi rolled her eyes and headed out the door. On the way, she was still thinking that Shen Hui really did have a great personality—to have been able to date Zhao Xuning for so long.

But thinking about the two of them and their tortuous love journey, Liang Shi couldn't help but sigh that true love was difficult.

By the time she finished buying groceries and returned home, Zhao Xuning had already gone to the hospital, leaving only her alone in the house.

Coincidentally, on her way back from buying groceries, she encountered a talent scout from an audition company who handed her a business card and went on and on trying to convince her, asking if she wanted to become a trainee.

Liang Shi looked at her in surprise: "Do I look like someone who can sing and dance?"

"You have great natural qualities. You can learn." The scout said. "Do you know Liu Xing? She's from our company."

Liang Shi did know her—she was a champion from an audition competition who had been extremely popular last year, a top-tier female celebrity with no close competition.

But Liang Shi wasn't interested in this and said she was an actress.

The scout immediately got excited and frantically pitched their company's acting department, saying that if Liang Shi joined, they would give her a lead female role.

Liang Shi's eyelid twitched at the time. She'd seen people who knew how to make empty promises¹, but she'd never seen someone this good at it.

Under that scout's relentless pestering, Liang Shi practically fled back home.

However, when she was eating and scrolling through her phone, she received an email.

It was to her work email.

The email subject clearly stated its purpose—it was an olive branch from Huayi Media's acting department, asking if she wanted to join Huayi Media.

Liang Shi thought about her current situation. She still lacked the ability to establish her own studio. In this industry, people weren't hard to find—plenty of people were desperate to break into this circle. Some fans would even frantically apply for related jobs just to get closer to their idols.

But good staff members were hard to find.

For someone like Liang Shi, most would end up paying high prices to hire newcomers with poor professional abilities.

But she also didn't want to sign under the company her big brother had mentioned before. When she became famous, wouldn't everyone digging into her background find out she was the third young miss of the Liang family?

And that wasn't even the scariest part—the scariest part was that she wasn't anymore.

How embarrassing would that be.

She had started over with a new identity and avoided any connection with Dongheng Group precisely to prevent this situation from happening.

To be an actress without relying on the power of capital. A well-behaved actress.

Simply treating this as a job, letting professionals handle professional matters.

After thinking it over, Liang Shi sent her resume to them and said they could arrange a time to discuss in detail.

The other party quickly agreed.

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1. The Chinese phrase "画饼" (huà bǐng, literally "drawing flatbread/pancakes") is an idiom meaning to make empty promises or paint unrealistic pictures to entice someone. It comes from the saying "画饼充饥" (drawing flatbread to satisfy hunger)—just as a picture of food can't actually feed you, empty promises can't deliver real results. ⇐

Chapter 157-8

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Huayi Media was a pretty good film and television company in the industry. From script development, IP selection, actors, screenwriters, to directors—it was practically a complete pipeline.

Moreover, they had been focused on the film and television industry for so many years.

In the years when talent shows had risen in popularity, Huayi Media hadn't thought about getting a piece of that pie and had always stayed focused on creating more and better films and dramas.

Yang Shuyan was signed to this company.

So the company was trustworthy—it just depended on the contract.

Liang Shi scheduled a meeting with their representative for ten o'clock the next morning, at a very ordinary café.

So ordinary that a cup of coffee cost less than 20 yuan, but the environment was surprisingly nice.

The Huayi representative was a short-haired girl with a small dimple when she smiled and very typical round eyes. She looked very approachable.

Based on her past experience, Liang Shi had drafted her own contract. Without much preamble, she went straight to the point and struck first.

When she brought out the contract, the girl was stunned.

She probably had never seen a newcomer bring their own contract when discussing collaboration. She struggled to hand over the contract she had brought, but Liang Shi's attitude was very firm. "I won't be looking at yours. The one I drafted is based on industry standards. You can take a look first—don't rush to reject it."

And just like that, Liang Shi went from a passive to an active position.

She sat there leisurely drinking coffee, and after about ten minutes, the other party had finished reading all the content of the contract.

There wasn't really anything too outrageous—it was almost the same as theirs, just with a few additional clauses regarding artist rights and contract termination protections.

Huayi was also a big company that had always valued developing their artists. Moreover, the company was governed primarily by "benevolence," and many big actors chose to stay with Huayi even after their contracts expired.

Because Huayi had good resources and was said to be backed by powerful capital, no one in the industry dared to mess with them.

Combined with their stable content output, they were considered one of the top talent agencies in terms of both reputation and strength, and wouldn't want to ruin their artist pipeline.

So after seeing this contract, the Huayi representative indeed didn't rush to reject it. Instead, she said: "I need to report this to my superior. You're quite unique. We're looking forward to working with you, but the contract terms need to be approved by our legal department before we can sign. So you can go home and wait for my message. I'll get back to you as soon as possible."

She was very polite to Liang Shi and didn't look down on her for being a lower-tier celebrity without any works.

So this person left a pretty good impression on Liang Shi.

For this reason, she even went so far as to message Zhao Ying, asking her what Huayi was like as a company and whether there were any hidden rules internally.

Zhao Ying was silent for a long time: 【Congratulations, little junior sister.】

Liang Shi:

Zhao Ying: 【I also signed with Huayi. We're about to be from the same agency.】

Liang Shi: "..."

After learning that Zhao Ying had also signed with Huayi, Liang Shi felt much more at ease.

She believed that her contract terms weren't too demanding, so she was quite confident about this collaboration.

Sure enough, a day later, the representative called Liang Shi and said her contract was acceptable and they could arrange the signing immediately.

Liang Shi went out again to sign the contract with them and took a tour around Huayi Media while she was there.

However, while walking around, she heard their employees whispering constantly. After a trip to the restroom, she figured out what was going on.

Apparently, there had been some turbulence in Huayi's upper management recently, and some unknown capital was trying to acquire Huayi.

Everyone gossiped for quite a while, and finally one person summed it up: "What does it have to do with me? I'm just here to work anyway."

Later, this matter fizzled out with no resolution.

Even Zhao Ying didn't know about it.

However, after signing with Huayi, she added her agent on WeChat. This agent was also quite famous in the industry. Countless artists had been made famous under her guidance, but she was particularly passionate about mentoring newcomers.

She said she really enjoyed the sense of achievement.

After Liang Shi added her, she was also pulled into a group chat with five people, all newcomers who had been signed to the company in the same batch.

Among them was Tang Zui, who had filmed "Mo Xin"¹ with her.

And Tang Zui said that Qi Tang had signed with another good talent agency.

This was probably the boost from Gu Yixue's film.

Although the casting and filming news for "Mo Xin" hadn't been publicly announced, basically everyone who was well-connected in the industry knew about it.

Some directors would even recommend actors to these talent agencies.

These talent agencies were probably thinking: how bad could someone who could act in a Gu Yixue film be?

However, for some reason, Sun Chengcheng hadn't been signed.

Perhaps she had gone after higher goals.

For this agent to manage five people at once would seem slightly difficult.

But clearly, she had already adapted to this method of collectively managing artists, and all her arrangements were very organized.

She first scheduled a meeting with everyone, and after the meeting, discussed career planning with each of them.

Among the artists signed in the same batch, all had acted before, and those artists all had works currently airing. Only Liang Shi and Tang Zui's works hadn't aired yet. But once they heard these two had acted in a Gu Yixue film, the others looked at them with indescribable envy.

Someone recognized Liang Shi and said she had been following her all along. She had gone viral with a set of photos in red clothing, and later someone even compared her red dress photos to Yang Shuyan's, concluding that each had their own merits.

The persona of a glamorous beauty with endless charm had been established on the internet.

So before meeting her in person, she had always thought Liang Shi was that kind of gorgeous, aloof, and arrogant queen. Only after meeting her did she discover she was actually a gentle older sister whose smile was so sweet.

Liang Shi even teased: "So does this count as breaking my persona?"

The young girl immediately waved her hands: "No, no, no, this is a new understanding."

You could tell within a few sentences whether an agent was capable or not.

Having gotten used to Sister Wang's swift and decisive work style, Liang Shi also accepted this new agent well—she was of the same caliber as Sister Wang.

However, the newcomers who hadn't signed with a company before were all a bit intimidated by this agent.

Tang Zui even whispered to her: "Sis, aren't you scared?"

"Why would I be scared of her?" Liang Shi said. "She's quite nice."

Tang Zui: "?"

Tang Zui felt like she didn't understand anymore.

When discussing career planning with her, Liang Shi said: "Act properly and behave. Necessary social engagements are fine, but not too many. For variety shows and such, only go on quality ones. Absolutely no over-marketing or excessive entertainment-ification, because all variety shows and endorsements are based on commercial value, and commercial value comes from works. This way, when people try to slander me, I can stand up and say I got to where I am today through my works."

The agent really appreciated her answer because it aligned with Huayi's philosophy.

Because the meeting with the agent went quite well, Liang Shi's mood improved somewhat.

She even took the initiative to ask Gu Yixue when she planned to crash the wedding.

In one more day, it would be the ten-day deadline that Shen Fenghe had mentioned.

Gu Yixue sent her a voice message in the middle of the night: "Tomorrow is the promotional release for 'Mo Xin.' Remember to repost on Weibo."

It was already the day before crashing the wedding, and Gu Yixue was still working hard. When Liang Shi saw her message, she replied instantly: **【Got it.】**

Gu Yixue was surprised: "Why aren't you asleep yet?"

Liang Shi: "I've been having insomnia lately."

Unlike Xu Qingzhu, she wasn't having nightmares—she simply couldn't fall asleep.

Gu Yixue didn't ask why she had insomnia. After all, for modern people, having an unholy sleep schedule² was pretty normal.

Instead, she answered Liang Shi's question: "On the day of her wedding, if Gu Chunmian doesn't show up, then I will."

Liang Shi: **【Brave!】**

Liang Shi: **【I'll carry the wedding dress for you and be your driver.】**

Gu Yixue: 【...Deal.】

And so the two of them casually finalized this matter in the middle of the night.

However, the day before Shen Fenghe's wedding, Liang Shi received a message from an unfamiliar number: 【Are you busy right now? I'd like to meet with you. —Gu Xingyue】

Gu Xingyue, who hadn't contacted her in a long time, suddenly sent a message. Liang Shi immediately replied: 【Yes, I'm free!】

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1. "Mo Xin" (心途) - The English title used in earlier translations was "Mo Xin" or could be translated as "Heart's Journey." This is the film directed by Gu Yixue that Liang Shi acted in. ↩
 2. The original Chinese phrase "阴间作息" (yīnjiān zuòxi) literally means "underworld/netherworld sleep schedule," referring to sleeping during the day and being awake at night like ghosts. It's internet slang used by young Chinese people to describe unhealthy sleep patterns, particularly staying up very late or having completely reversed day-night schedules. ↩

Chapter 157-9

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It was still the same café where she had met with the Huayi representative last time. Gu Xingyue, whom she hadn't seen in a long time, had become quite thin. The baby fat on her face was completely gone, making her chin appear somewhat sharp. The gentle temperament she used to have was no longer there, replaced by—a sense of mystery.

That was the only word Liang Shi could use to describe it.

Because no other word was quite fitting.

Gu Xingyue was wearing a pea-green knitted dress. Her coat was haute couture from a very niche foreign designer brand, probably costing six figures. It was in gray tones, but it didn't look out of place.

She sat in the sunlight, yet there was no light in her eyes.

Liang Shi nodded in greeting and sat across from her. "Long time no see."

It was a very clichéd opening line.

Gu Xingyue smiled at her. "Long time no see."

All the qualities that belonged to "Qi Jiao" had completely dissipated from her. What remained was only Gu Xingyue.

Liang Shi said in a low voice: "Congratulations on your rebirth."

"Yes." Gu Xingyue said. "Thank you for helping me make up my mind."

Liang Shi asked if she had been in contact with Gu Zhaoyuan. Gu Xingyue slowly shook her head. "I've only seen him once."

It was at Gu Yingbo's funeral.

And because Gu Xingyue had been injured before, she had been staying at the hospital these past days.

She had very little contact with the outside world.

Liang Shi asked her: "You haven't seen anyone at all?"

Gu Xingyue nodded: "I've been contemplating life during those days."

"And what did you figure out?"

"Nothing." Gu Xingyue shrugged. "But I did finish writing a novel."

Liang Shi: "?"

Gu Xingyue smiled slightly. "I think I understand now why Qi Jiao liked to write in her diary."

"What?" Liang Shi asked.

Gu Xingyue: "Writing can calm a person down."

Liang Shi nodded: "That's pretty nice, finding something you like to do."

Because of Gu Xingyue's special identity, the Qi family's company ultimately still fell into her hands.

Because legally, she was still Qi Jiao, the person with legal inheritance rights.

That company with a nine-figure valuation fell to Gu Xingyue, but Gu Xingyue had no talent in this area. Qi Xiangui had acted as if he never thought he would die, so he had never taught Gu Xingyue any skills for managing a company.

Gu Xingyue sold the company. Half of the assets were donated to the nation, one-third to charitable organizations, and another third to orphanages. She kept only the small remainder for herself.

It had also been two days since Yang Jiani's court hearing.

She hadn't been paying attention to these matters these days. Probably because the evidence was too conclusive, Liang Shi hadn't been summoned as a witness.

She also heard about it from Gu Xingyue.

The most shocking news was: Yang Jiani had committed suicide.

The procuratorate had sentenced Yang Jiani to life imprisonment. On the way from the procuratorate to the prison, Yang Jiani had somehow obtained a piece of string and strangled herself.

Unexpected.

But within reason.

Someone like Yang Jiani probably felt that life was hopeless and then atoned for her sins in this way.

Liang Shi was surprised for quite a while when she heard this.

Gu Xingyue shook her head and said: "I wanted to tell you that day, but your phone couldn't get through."

"I had something going on and turned off my phone for a couple of days." Liang Shi said.

"Anyway, we're both liberated now." As Gu Xingyue spoke, she took out a USB drive from her bag and handed it over. "This thing—you probably won't want to see it, but I'll give it to you anyway."

Liang Shi frowned: "What is this?"

Gu Xingyue paused briefly: "Some videos of you and Qi Jiao from when you were children."

"You must be mentally prepared before watching." Gu Xingyue said. "But I suggest you don't watch it. Just forget about those things."

Liang Shi: "...Alright."

When Liang Shi picked up the USB drive, she felt as if it was heavy.

She didn't know why she had this feeling.

Liang Shi looked at her and suddenly spoke up in the silence: "Have you ever thought about who your biological parents are?"

Gu Xingyue was startled: "Why do you ask?"

Liang Shi thought about it and still said: "I... probably know who your biological mother is."

Her speech paused, and because of nervousness, she stumbled over her breathing several times in the wrong places.

Gu Xingyue fell silent again.

Liang Shi didn't know whether she should continue, but after a long while, Gu Xingyue asked: "Is she still alive?"

Liang Shi immediately nodded: "And she's been looking for you all along."

"How do you know?" Gu Xingyue asked.

Liang Shi immediately said: "You know your blood type is very rare, right? That day when you lost too much blood, the only blood bag in the blood bank that matched your blood type had a rejection reaction when they were transfusing it to you. It happened to be my friend's teacher. Because she was suspicious, she went and did a DNA test, and then..."

This was indeed a beautiful accident.

But Liang Shi felt that this kind of accident was quite nice.

After hearing this, Gu Xingyue felt like it was surreal and even began to doubt the authenticity of the matter: "You're not lying to me?"

Liang Shi: "...Why would I lie to you?"

"That report is with my friend right now." Liang Shi said. "And your mother is a literature professor at a university. Though we're not clear about her marital status. According to my friend, she often goes to see doctors alone."

Gu Xingyue hesitated.

Liang Shi added more fuel to the fire: "Do you want to go see your biological mother? Even if you don't acknowledge each other, you could at least meet."

Gu Xingyue: "..."

"After all, you're all alone now." Liang Shi said. "It's always good to have family around."

Gu Xingyue wavered. After a moment, she asked: "What's her name?"

"Feng Xian." Liang Shi said.